

Memory versus Monument Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-45 min

Category	History	Time	30-45 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	memory-versus-monument

Big idea: Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Memory versus Monument Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Memory versus Monument Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Memory versus Monument Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Memory versus Monument Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Memory versus Monument Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Memory versus Monument Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How is public memory different from historical knowledge?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note.
- Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

- 1. Show a memorial image and ask what knowledge it seems to communicate.
- 2. Give a personal memory and an archival source about the same event.
- 3. Students compare purpose, evidence, emotion, and omissions.
- 4. Groups decide what each source helps us know and what it cannot settle.
- 5. Debrief the difference between remembering and explaining the past.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How is public memory different from historical knowledge?
- Can a monument be evidence, interpretation, and argument at once?
- Whose responsibility is it to revise public memory?

Knowledge Questions

- How is public memory different from historical knowledge?
- What can monuments help us know and what can they hide?
- How do emotion and evidence interact in history?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a monument plaque compared with personal memory accounts. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...